Legal Practice Management SaaS

Full Product Specification for the Sri Lankan Market

Prepared as a developer-ready specification for building a multi-tenant SaaS platform for lawyers and law firms in Sri Lanka.

Includes product scope, modules, workflows, wireframes, startup pitch, and conversion risks.

Intended use: Feed this document into Claude-Code as the functional blueprint for architecture, database design, APIs, pages, and phased delivery.

1. Executive Summary

This SaaS platform is intended to digitize the day-to-day operations of lawyers and law firms in Sri Lanka. It should serve solo practitioners, small and medium firms, and eventually larger legal practices that need structured case handling, client management, court scheduling, billing, document control, and secure collaboration.

The system must be multi-tenant, secure, modular, and easy to adopt for professionals who may currently rely on paper files, notebooks, WhatsApp conversations, and fragmented spreadsheets. Its competitive advantage should come from local legal workflow alignment, strong reminders and automation, clean usability, and support for business operations beyond pure case tracking.

2. Product Goals

- Centralize all firm data: clients, matters, hearings, documents, tasks, and invoices.
- Reduce missed deadlines, adjournments, follow-ups, and unmanaged client expectations.
- Create a repeatable operating system for legal work rather than just a digital file cabinet.
- Support both solo lawyers and firm teams using permissions, workflows, and collaboration.
- Enable future AI features such as summarization, drafting assistance, and intelligent search.

3. Target Users

User Type	Description	Primary Need
Solo Lawyer	Independent practitioner handling matters personally	Simple all-in-one system with reminders, documents, and billing
Law Firm Owner / Admin	Manages practice operations and performance	Visibility, control, billing, team oversight, and reporting
Associate Lawyer	Handles assigned matters and client work	Case workflow, collaboration, timeline, and documents
Clerk / Legal Assistant	Supports filing, scheduling, records, and admin	Task execution, deadlines, filing status, and document control
Client	Receives legal services from the firm	Updates, documents, invoices, and secure communication

4. Core Pain Points to Solve

- Paper-heavy case handling and unstructured office record keeping
- Missed court dates, filing deadlines, and client follow-ups
- No single source of truth for case status or hearing history
- Scattered communication across calls, email, and messaging platforms
- Weak billing discipline and poor tracking of receivables
- Limited visibility for firm owners over lawyer workload and case progress
- Difficulty searching documents, notes, or prior precedents quickly
- Inconsistent service quality when a practice grows beyond one person

5. Functional Scope Overview

Module	Must Have in MVP	Business Outcome
User & Role Management	Yes	Secure multi-user firm operation
Client Management	Yes	Central client records and history
Matter / Case Management	Yes	Structured handling of legal work
Court & Hearing Calendar	Yes	Deadline control and operational visibility
Task Management	Yes	Daily execution and delegation
Document Management	Yes	Digital file system with case linkage
Billing & Invoicing	Yes	Revenue tracking and collections
Communication Logs	Yes	Case-linked interaction history
Time Tracking	Yes	Billable work capture
Expense Tracking	Yes	Matter profitability and reimbursables
Client Portal	Phase 2 / Optional MVP	Transparency and better service
AI Assistant	Phase 3	Higher productivity and differentiation

6. Detailed Module Specification

6.1 User, Firm, and Role Management

- Multi-tenant architecture where each law firm has isolated data.
- Firm profile: firm name, address, branding, contact details, timezone, subscription plan.
- Users: owner, partner, lawyer, clerk, cashier/accounting, receptionist, client portal user.
- Role-based access control with configurable permissions by module and action.
- Support invitation workflow, password reset, session management, and optional MFA.

6.2 Client Relationship Management

- Create and maintain individual and corporate client profiles.
- Store NIC, passport, company registration, addresses, phone numbers, emails, and contacts.
- Track linked matters, bills, documents, and communications.
- Store client-specific notes, conflict-check information, and relationship tags.
- Client intake workflow with source, consultation date, assigned lawyer, and onboarding checklist.

6.3 Matter / Case Management

- Matter types: civil, criminal, family, labour, land, commercial, tax, arbitration, conveyancing, notarial, compliance, and advisory.
- Core fields: title, internal reference, court case number, court, jurisdiction, stage, priority, status, opponent, assigned team, filing date, next action date.
- Link multiple clients and multiple lawyers to one matter.
- Maintain structured notes, hearing history, document links, tasks, invoices, and expenses.
- Case status flow examples: intake, consultation, retained, draft, filed, awaiting hearing, adjourned, evidence stage, judgment pending, closed.

6.4 Court, Hearing, and Deadline Management

- Maintain court directory relevant to Sri Lanka: Magistrate Courts, District Courts, High Courts, Court of Appeal, Supreme Court, tribunals, and quasi-judicial bodies.
- Schedule hearings, mentions, submissions, consultations, and filing deadlines.
- Track hearing outcomes: adjourned, filed, argument heard, evidence recorded, order issued, judgment delivered.
- Automatic reminders by email first; design for SMS/WhatsApp later.
- Daily agenda, weekly agenda, and lawyer-specific docket view.

6.5 Task and Workflow Management

- Tasks linked to matters or standalone administrative tasks.
- Assign to lawyer, clerk, or admin with due date, priority, status, and checklist.
- Recurrence for common legal office routines.
- Workflow templates by matter type, for example land transfer, divorce, bail application, company incorporation, or litigation.
- Escalation rules for overdue tasks and approaching deadlines.

6.6 Document Management

- Upload and organize documents by matter and category.
- Categories include briefs, petitions, affidavits, motions, agreements, exhibits, correspondence, invoices, receipts, court orders, and internal notes.
- Version control, uploader, timestamp, and optionally approval status.
- Full-text search readiness and OCR support in future phases.
- Signed URL access, download controls, and matter-level restrictions.

6.7 Billing, Payments, and Accounts Receivable

- Fee models: consultation fee, fixed fee, hourly fee, stage-based fee, retainer, and reimbursement.
- Generate quotations, retainers, invoices, credit notes, receipts, and statements.
- Track unpaid balances, due dates, partial payments, and follow-up reminders.
- Support LKR currency by default and tax configuration where required.
- Matter-level financial summary showing billed, paid, expenses, and outstanding.

6.8 Communication Tracking

- Log phone calls, client meetings, emails, WhatsApp summaries, and internal discussions.
- Link all communication records to the relevant matter and client.
- Store next follow-up action and owner.
- Optional Gmail / Outlook sync in later phase.
- This module is critical because legal services are relationship-heavy and memory-dependent.

6.9 Time Tracking

- Start/stop timer and manual time entry per matter.
- Categorize time by consultation, drafting, research, court attendance, travel, internal discussion, or filing.
- Mark entries as billable or non-billable.
- Push approved time into invoice items.
- Support performance analytics and profitability measurement.

6.10 Expense Tracking

- Record filing fees, stamp duty, travel costs, photocopying, courier charges, and third-party disbursements.
- Attach receipts or supporting files.

- Mark whether recoverable from client or internal firm expense.
- Surface total case spend and reimbursable values.

6.11 Client Portal

- Client login to view matter status, documents shared with them, hearing dates, invoices, receipts, and messages.
- Limited visibility only to client-approved data.
- Secure messaging or question submission.
- A major trust-building feature for premium plans.

6.12 Legal Template and Knowledge Library

- Clause bank and reusable templates for agreements, affidavits, motions, demand letters, notices, and petitions.
- Auto-fill placeholders using client and matter data.
- Store internal knowledge notes and precedent references.
- This is a crucial productivity feature often missed in generic CRMs.

6.13 Audit, Compliance, and Security

- Immutable audit trail for edits, uploads, status changes, and access to sensitive records.
- Case-level and document-level permissions.
- Encryption in transit and at rest.
- Optional data export and local backup options.
- Administrative logs for login history, failed attempts, and unusual access patterns.

7. Features That Are Crucial for Lawyers and Often Missed

Feature	Why It Matters	Priority
Legal template library	Lawyers repeatedly draft similar documents and clauses	High
Case timeline visualization	Legal matters progress through events, not flat records	High
Communication log	A large share of legal work happens through calls and updates	High
Time tracking	Required for hourly billing and profitability	High
Expense management	Disbursements and filing costs must be recovered accurately	High
Filing workflow / checklist	Ensures documents are prepared, reviewed, and filed correctly	High
Audit trail	Essential for trust, supervision, and dispute handling	High
Multi-lawyer collaboration	Firms need shared work without confusion	High
Client portal	Improves transparency and reduces repetitive client calls	Medium-High
Offline resilience	Useful in low-connectivity or field/court environments	Medium

8. Non-Functional Requirements

- Fast search across clients, matters, documents, and tasks.
- Responsive web application that works well on desktop and tablet.
- Clean UI requiring minimal training for first-time legal users.
- Robust backup and restore strategy.
- Scalable architecture to handle many firms and many documents.
- Configurable notifications and locale settings.
- Good auditability, observability, and error monitoring.

9. Suggested Technology Stack

Layer	Recommendation	Notes
Frontend	React + TypeScript	Fast iteration, reusable component system, good fit for Claude-Code
UI	Tailwind CSS + component library	Clean dashboard-style interface
Backend	Node.js + NestJS or Express	Modular APIs and multi-tenant architecture
Database	PostgreSQL	Strong relational modeling for legal entities
Storage	AWS S3 or Supabase Storage	Documents and attachments
Auth	Supabase Auth or custom JWT	Depends on hosting preference
Notifications	Email first, then SMS/WhatsApp integrations	Phase rollout recommended
Hosting	AWS / Railway / Render / Vercel mix	Choose based on ops comfort and cost

10. High-Level Data Model

- Firm
- User
- Role / Permission
- Client
- Client Contact
- Matter / Case
- Court
- Hearing / Event
- Task
- Document
- Document Version
- Time Entry
- Expense
- Invoice
- Invoice Item
- Payment
- Communication Log
- Template

- Audit Log
- Notification

11. Key Workflows

11.1 New Client Intake

1. Create or search existing client record.
2. Run conflict-check notes or manual confirmation.
3. Capture consultation details and intake summary.
4. Create matter, assign responsible lawyer, set first tasks.
5. Upload initial documents and set next date/reminder.

11.2 Litigation Matter Workflow

6. Open matter and record court/case number.
7. Upload pleadings and maintain filing checklist.
8. Schedule hearing/mention dates.
9. Record outcome after each appearance.
10. Create follow-up tasks, client update, and billable entries.
11. Move matter to closed when complete.

11.3 Billing Workflow

12. Capture billable time and expenses.
13. Prepare invoice or retainer drawdown.
14. Send invoice to client.
15. Track due date and payment status.
16. Issue receipt and update outstanding balance.

11.4 Reminder Workflow

17. System identifies upcoming deadline, hearing, or unpaid invoice.
18. Notification rule triggers based on role and urgency.
19. Assigned user receives email reminder.
20. Matter dashboard highlights the due item until resolved.

12. UI Wireframes (Low-Fidelity)

12.1 Main Dashboard

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┌──────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────┐
│ Logo | Global Search | Notifications | Quick Add | User Menu             |
├──────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────┤
│ KPI: Active Matters | Today Hearings | Unpaid Invoices | Overdue Tasks   |
├──────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────┤
│ Left Menu              | Today’s Agenda                                  |
│ - Dashboard            | 10:00 AM   District Court - Matter A            |
│ - Clients              | 11:30 AM   Client Meeting - Matter B            |
│ - Matters              |  2:00 PM   Filing Deadline - Matter C           |
│ - Calendar             ├─────────────────────────────────────────────────┤
│ - Documents            | Recent Activity                                 |
│ - Billing              | - Document uploaded                             |
│ - Reports              | - Hearing outcome updated                       |
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| - Settings            | - Invoice generated                                |
└──────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────┘
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12.2 Matter Detail Screen

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┌──────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────┐
| Matter Title | Status | Priority | Assigned Team | Next Date              |
├──────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────┤
| Tabs: Overview | Timeline | Hearings | Tasks | Documents | Billing | Notes |
├──────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────┤
| Client Info            | Opponent / Other Party                          |
| Court / Case No        | Latest Update                                   |
| Matter Stage           | Action Buttons: Add Hearing / Upload / Add Task |
├──────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────┤
| Timeline                                                        [visual]  |
| Intake → Filing → Hearing 1 → Adjournment → Hearing 2 → Judgment          |
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12.3 Calendar / Docket View

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┌──────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────┐
| Filters: Lawyer | Court | Matter Type | Date Range | View: Day/Week/Month |
├──────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────┤
| 09:00 | Consultation                                                |    |
| 10:00 | Court Mention                                               |    |
| 11:00 | Drafting Block                                              |    |
| 14:00 | Filing Deadline                                             |    |
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12.4 Billing Screen

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┌──────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────┐
| Client | Matter | Amount | Due Date | Status | Actions                   |
├──────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────┤
| + Create Invoice | + Record Payment | + Add Expense                      |
├──────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────┤
| Invoice Detail                                                          |
| - Fee Items                                                             |
| - Time Logs                                                             |
| - Expenses                                                              |
| - Total / Paid / Outstanding                                            |
└──────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────┘
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12.5 Client Portal

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┌──────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────┐
| Welcome Client | Matters | Documents | Invoices | Messages               |
├──────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────┤
| Matter Summary                                                          |
| - Current stage                                                         |
| - Upcoming date                                                         |
| - Shared documents                                                      |
| - Ask a question                                                        |
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13. Startup Pitch

13.1 Problem

Lawyers in Sri Lanka often manage their practice using a mix of paper files, phone calls, scattered messages, ad hoc clerical processes, and fragmented billing records. This creates missed deadlines, slow client response, poor financial control, and limited scalability.

13.2 Solution

Build a cloud-based legal practice management platform tailored for Sri Lanka. The product should combine matter management, court scheduling, document control, billing, communication logs, and workflow automation in one secure system designed around actual legal office behavior.

13.3 Why Now

Law practices increasingly need operational discipline, digital collaboration, and better client service, yet many are still underserved by software that understands local working methods. A localized platform with strong automation can capture this gap.

13.4 Business Model

- Monthly subscription tiers: Solo, Small Firm, Growth Firm, Enterprise.
- Paid add-ons: SMS packs, extra storage, AI drafting/summarization, onboarding support.
- Possible white-label offering for bar associations or legal networks.

13.5 Competitive Advantage

- Built specifically for Sri Lankan legal workflows
- Simple adoption path for lawyers moving from paper/manual systems
- Automation-first design for reminders, billing follow-up, and task execution
- Expandable into AI-powered legal productivity tools

14. Foreseeable Challenges in Conversion and Adoption

Challenge	What It Means	Recommended Response
Resistance to change	Many lawyers are comfortable with paper and manual habits	Make onboarding simple, provide demos, and keep UI extremely clear
Data migration difficulty	Existing records may be in notebooks, Word files, scans, and messaging apps	Provide assisted onboarding, CSV imports, and gradual migration
Trust and confidentiality concerns	Legal data is highly sensitive	Emphasize security, permissions, audit logs, backups, and optional private hosting
Pricing sensitivity	Solo lawyers may hesitate at high recurring costs	Offer an affordable entry tier and demonstrate ROI clearly
Workflow diversity	Different firms operate differently	Use flexible statuses, templates, and configurable workflows
Notification complexity	Reliable local SMS/WhatsApp setup may take time	Start with email and design extensible notification architecture
Document sprawl	Legal work generates many files and versions	Invest early in search, categorization, and version control
Scope creep	Trying to digitize everything at once may slow delivery	Ship an MVP with the highest daily-use value first

15. Recommended MVP

- Firm, user, and role management

- Client intake and client records
- Matter/case management
- Court/hearing calendar and reminders
- Tasks and internal notes
- Document upload and organization
- Communication logs
- Billing, invoices, payments, and basic expenses
- Basic reporting dashboard

16. Phase Roadmap

Phase	Scope
Phase 1 - MVP	Core legal operations: clients, matters, hearings, tasks, documents, billing
Phase 2 - Growth	Client portal, richer reports, time tracking enhancements, template library
Phase 3 - Differentiation	AI assistant, OCR/search, email integrations, advanced analytics
Phase 4 - Expansion	Mobile apps, association partnerships, regional scaling

17. Claude-Code Build Direction

Use this specification as the source document for Claude-Code. Ask Claude-Code to generate the platform in modular stages:

21. Create the multi-tenant backend architecture and authentication model.
22. Generate the PostgreSQL schema and migrations.
23. Build REST or GraphQL APIs for each module.
24. Create the web application pages, layouts, and forms.
25. Implement permissions and tenant isolation.
26. Add notification jobs and background processing.
27. Write tests for the highest-risk workflows.
28. Prepare seed data for Sri Lankan courts and common matter types.

18. Closing Note

This product should not be approached as a generic CRM for lawyers. It must function as a true operating system for legal practice, covering both legal work and the business mechanics around it. The closer the product gets to real lawyer pain points—deadlines, drafting, follow-ups, documents, billing, confidentiality, and team execution—the stronger its market fit will be.